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The good old days?

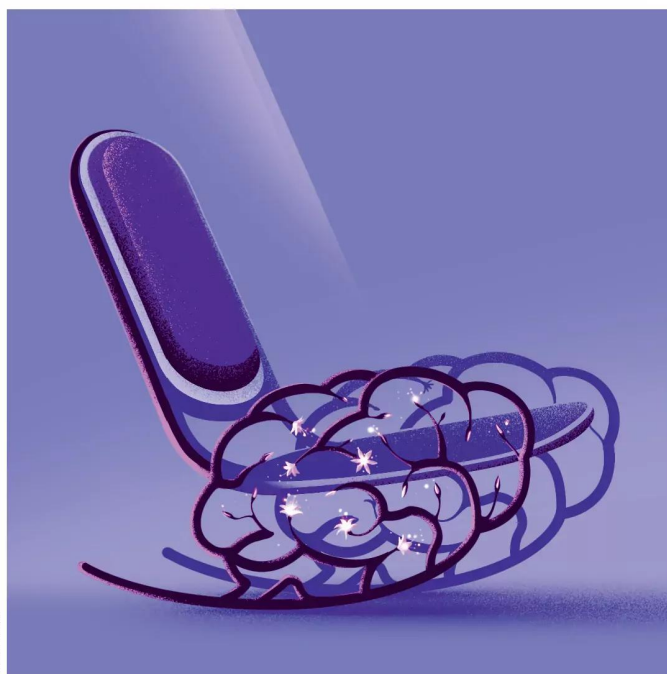
Nostalgia isn't only about a rose-tinted view of the past. It can also be put to use in unexpected places – including work, says **Agnes Arnold-Forster**

FOR hundreds of years, nostalgia wasn't just an emotion, but a potentially deadly disease. Coined by a Swiss physician in 1688, nostalgia struck down servants in 17th-century Germany and killed soldiers in their thousands during the American Civil War. It was a kind of pathological homesickness and while its exact mechanism is unclear, it caused people to slowly waste away. Weak and unable to eat, some starved to death.

These days, we view nostalgia very differently. Now, psychologists and neuroscientists think nostalgia is a predominantly positive, albeit bittersweet, emotion that arises from personally salient, tender, wistful memories of one's past.

But nostalgia isn't just benign. It is also actively therapeutic – a powerful psychological resource that provides people with a variety of benefits. Researchers have found it can boost self-esteem, increase meaning in life, foster a sense of social connectedness and reduce loneliness, stress and anxiety. It can even be used to maintain and improve memory among older adults, enrich psychological health and lessen depression, studies show.

This therapeutic version of nostalgia has been put to use in unexpected places. Organisations of various kinds have tapped into nostalgia's feel-good factor and companies have deployed the emotion in their efforts to improve workforce well-being.



ADRIA VOLTA

The sociologist Yiannis Gabriel was one of the first to coin the term “organisational nostalgia”. He found that nostalgia is a by-product of workplaces where employees have spent many years, especially when the organisation is central to the local community, like coal mines, hospitals and universities. His research subjects told nostalgic stories about former colleagues and reminisced over old office buildings.

Later studies found that organisational nostalgia could be put to use. It strengthened the professional identities of academics, doctors and nurses, for

example, and could be deployed as a personal psychological resource.

Nostalgia at work can look like shared recollections about memorable days in a company's history, or more abstract feelings about the “golden age” of a profession. Psychologists found that this organisational nostalgia helps employees cope with a challenging boss. It could act as an emotional buffer, allowing staff to maintain a feeling of motivation and – helpfully for employers – stop them seeking improved working conditions or altered leadership.

Despite the frustrations of, say,

being denied a voice in important decisions at work, researchers have found that nostalgia provides an “alternative route to social connectedness” that keeps employees cooperative.

One study that interviewed 23 academics in Finland found they yearned for a past when they had more academic freedom. This “idealization of the past” helped the academics clarify their professional values, researchers found, which helped them come to terms with current pressures. And when medical professionals had their autonomy threatened by new ways of working, they could draw on nostalgia to make themselves feel better.

This is all also great news for managers. A major challenge for big organisations is getting people to forgo self-interest and contribute to the collective good. As nostalgia can foster feelings of connectedness, it may make staff more willing to engage in behaviour that benefits their colleagues and the organisation's needs. Other studies have found it even improves staff retention.

While savvy managers can lean on nostalgia to help them get their staff onside, employees can use this research to see where their nostalgia for the workplace could be clouding their judgement. ■



Agnes Arnold-Forster is a historian and author of *Nostalgia: A history of a dangerous emotion*

■ Academic Vocabulary Focus

Key terms from the New Scientist article “The good old days?” by Agnes Arnold-Forster. These words will help you understand the text more deeply.

Word	POS	Definition	Example / Context from Article
pathological	adj.	Relating to or caused by disease; extreme or unhealthy in degree.	Nostalgia was once viewed as a pathological homesickness that could kill people.
therapeutic	adj.	Having a healing or beneficial effect; relating to treatment.	This therapeutic version of nostalgia is now used in workplaces to improve well-being.
organisational nostalgia	n.	Nostalgic feelings connected to one's workplace, colleagues or professional history.	Sociologist Yiannis Gabriel coined the term “ organisational nostalgia ”.
idealization	n.	The act of viewing or portraying something as better or more perfect than it really is.	This “ idealization of the past” helped academics clarify their professional values.
autonomy	n.	Freedom from external control; the right to self-govern or make independent decisions.	When doctors and nurses had their autonomy threatened, they used nostalgia to feel better.
bittersweet	adj.	Pleasant but mixed with sadness; having both positive and negative qualities.	Nostalgia is described as a predominantly positive, albeit bittersweet , emotion.
social connectedness	n.	The sense of belonging and having meaningful relationships with others.	Nostalgia provides an “alternative route to social connectedness ” at work.
retention	n.	The action of keeping or continuing to have something; employee loyalty to a company.	Studies show that organisational nostalgia can improve staff retention .

■ Comprehension Questions

Answer the following questions based on the New Scientist article. Questions 1–6 are multiple choice. Questions 7–10 are gap-fill exercises.

Multiple Choice Questions

1. Historically, how was nostalgia viewed?

- A) As a positive emotion that improves mental health
- B) As a potentially deadly disease caused by pathological homesickness
- C) As a modern invention with no real effects
- D) As a harmless form of daydreaming

2. What did sociologist Yiannis Gabriel study?

- A) The history of nostalgia as a disease
- B) "Organisational nostalgia" in workplaces like hospitals and universities
- C) The effects of LED light pollution
- D) The rise of weight loss drugs

3. How can organisational nostalgia help employees cope at work?

- A) It encourages them to demand better pay immediately
- B) It acts as an emotional buffer and helps them deal with a difficult boss
- C) It makes them more likely to quit their jobs
- D) It has no positive effect according to research

4. What did the Finnish study of academics show?

- A) They wanted more money
- B) Yearning for more academic freedom in the past helped them clarify their professional values
- C) They had no interest in the past
- D) Nostalgia made them less productive

5. Why is nostalgia useful for managers?

- A) It makes employees demand changes to leadership
- B) It can improve staff retention and make employees more cooperative
- C) It has no effect on workplace behaviour
- D) It only benefits the employees, not the company

6. What caution does the article give to employees?

- A) They should never feel nostalgic
- B) Their nostalgia might be clouding their judgement about current working conditions
- C) Nostalgia always leads to better jobs
- D) They should only focus on the future

Gap-Fill Questions

Complete the sentences using the words in the box.

Word Bank: pathological • therapeutic • organisational nostalgia • idealization • autonomy • bittersweet • social connectedness • retention

7. In the past, nostalgia was considered a _____ condition that could even cause death.

8. Today, nostalgia is recognised as a _____ emotion that can reduce stress and improve well-being.

9. The _____ of the past helped academics in Finland clarify their professional values.

10. Research suggests that organisational nostalgia can improve staff _____ in companies.

Note: An answer key can be provided separately. Review the original article to check your answers.